

PRE-ŚAṆKARA VEDĀNTA

Gauḍapāda-Kārikā

Comprehensive Study Notes

Source: C. D. Sharma, *A Critical Survey of Indian Philosophy*, Chapter XIV
("Pre-Shankara Vedanta"), pp. 239-251

Notes preserve the full argumentative structure of the original chapter — every proof, counter-proof, analogy and citation — reorganised under analytical headings for study and revision.

Structure of these notes

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- **III.** Reality as Pure Consciousness — convergence with, and divergence from, Vijñānavāda
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I. THE TEXT AND ITS STATUS IN THE VEDĀNTA TRADITION

1.1 The Prasthāna-traya and the Buddhist Parallel

The Upaniṣads, the Brahma-Sūtra and the Gītā together form the **Prasthāna-traya**, the three basic works of Vedānta, on which almost every great Ācārya has written a commentary.

Sharma opens with a structural analogy between the development of Mahāyāna Buddhism and the development of Advaita Vedānta:

- The various schools of Mahāyāna recognise the *Mahāyāna-Sūtras* as the Āgama embodying the real teaching of the Buddha. These teachings were first **summarised** by **Aśvaghoṣa**, the first systematic expounder of Mahāyāna, and then **developed into a full-fledged school** (Śūnyavāda) by its first systematic expounder, **Nāgārjuna**.
- In exactly parallel fashion, the Upaniṣads are regarded as *śruti* by the Vedāntins. Their teaching was **summarised** by **Bādarāyaṇa** in the Brahma-Sūtra, and then **developed into the school of Advaita Vedānta** by its first systematic expounder, **Gauḍapāda**.

This parallel is not decorative for Sharma: it frames his entire interpretive thesis for the chapter — that Advaita and Mahāyāna are two branches growing from a common root rather than one having simply copied the other (developed at 1.3.4 below and again in Section V).

The **Māṇḍūkya-Kārikā**, also called the **Gauḍapāda-Kārikā** or the **Āgama-Śāstra**, is the first available systematic treatise on Advaita Vedānta. Gauḍapāda's philosophy is essentially grounded in the Upaniṣads, particularly the **Māṇḍūkya**, the **Bṛhadāraṇyaka**, and the **Chāndogya**; he has probably also drawn upon the Brahma-Sūtra and the Gītā. At the same time, he is unmistakably influenced by Mahāyāna Buddhism — by both **Śūnyavāda** and **Vijñānavāda**. Sharma states this influence in strong terms: it can correctly be said that **Gauḍapāda represents the best that is in Nāgārjuna and Vasubandhu**.

1.2 Gauḍapāda's Place in the Guru-Paramparā

Tradition holds that Gauḍapāda was the teacher of **Govindapāda**, who was the teacher of **Śaṅkarācārya**. The lineage is affirmed by Śaṅkara himself and by his own disciple:

- Śaṅkara most respectfully salutes Gauḍapāda as his "grand-teacher who is the respected (teacher) of his respected (teacher)" — the closing verse of the *Māṇḍūkya-Kārikā-Bhāṣya*.
- Śaṅkara quotes from Gauḍapāda and refers to him as "the teacher who knows the tradition of the Vedānta" (cf. *Śārīraka-Bhāṣya* II.1.9 and I.4.14).

- Śaṅkara's own disciple **Sureśvara** refers to Gauḍapāda as the "Revered Gauḍa" (*Naiṣkarmya-siddhi* IV.44).

1.3 The Vidhuśekhara Bhaṭṭācārya Controversy

The long-accepted traditional view is that the Kārikās of Gauḍapāda are a **commentary on the Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad**. This view is challenged by **Pt. Vidhuśekhara Bhaṭṭācārya**, whose thesis (in the Introduction to his edition of *The Āgama-Śāstra of Gauḍapāda*) has three parts:

- 1 The Kārikās of Book I are **not** an exposition of the Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad.
- 2 The Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad is **mainly based on the Kārikās**, and not the reverse.
- 3 Consequently, the Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad is **later than the Kārikās**.

Sharma finds every argument offered for this thesis "entirely unconvincing." He states Bhaṭṭācārya's four supporting arguments and answers each in turn.

1.3.1 First Debate — Is Book I a Commentary on the Upaniṣad?

Bhaṭṭācārya's four arguments:

- 1 **Madhva's authority.** Madhva regards only Book I as Śruti, and holds that the other three Books form a separate work (or works) which he does not comment upon.
- 2 **Unexplained vocabulary.** The Kārikās do not explain many important and difficult words that occur in the Māṇḍūkya.
- 3 **Borrowing.** The Māṇḍūkya has drawn upon other Upaniṣads and upon the Kārikās themselves.
- 4 **Comparative lateness of prose.** Comparing certain prose passages of the Māṇḍūkya with corresponding Kārikās shows that the prose passages are the later development.

Sharma's rebuttals, point by point:

- 1 **Against (1):** Śaṅkara and Sureśvara — both Advaitins, and both flourishing long before Madhva, who is a Dvaitin — do **not** regard the Kārikās as Śruti. Bhaṭṭācārya gives no sound reason why Madhva's authority should be preferred over that of Śaṅkara and Sureśvara.
- 2 **Against (2):** The Kārikās are a **free commentary**, almost an independent work, based essentially on the Upaniṣad. It was therefore not necessary for Gauḍapāda to gloss every single word occurring in the Māṇḍūkya text — the absence of word-by-word explanation proves nothing about relative chronology.
- 3 **Against (3):** Sharma *concedes* that the Māṇḍūkya has much similarity with the Bṛhadāraṇyaka and the Chāndogya, and adds that many passages found in these two Upaniṣads also recur in Upaniṣads other than the Māṇḍūkya. But even granting that the Māṇḍūkya is late and has drawn on earlier Upaniṣads, **this does not entail that it drew upon the Kārikās** — the two borrowings are logically independent claims.

- 4 **Against (4):** Comparing the prose passages of the Māṇḍūkya with the Kārikās shows, Sharma argues, **exactly the opposite** of Bhaṭṭācārya's claim: the prose passages appear to be the earlier ones. Moreover, scholars have generally held that the prose portions of the Upaniṣads as a class are earlier than their verse portions — a general philological consideration that favours Sharma's reading.

1.3.2 Second Debate — Are the Four Books Independent Treatises?

Bhaṭṭācārya's further contention is that the four Books are "four independent treatises... put together in a volume under the title of the Āgama-Śāstra." Sharma calls this "untenable" too. Bhaṭṭācārya's supporting arguments:

- 1 If Book II is supported by independent reasoning, does that mean there is **no reasoning at all** in Book I?
- 2 Does one find in Book II anything improper, nonsensical, unintelligible or incomplete **without** assuming its connection to Book I? Bhaṭṭācārya's answer: No — hence Book II stands independently.
- 3 There is nothing against supposing that Book III, too, is an independent work.
- 4 Certain doctrines — e.g. **Ajātivāda** — already indicated in Book I and discussed in Book III are **discussed again** in Book IV. Why would the author of Book IV indulge in such a useless repetition, unless Book IV were an independent composition?

Sharma's rebuttals:

- 1 If Gauḍapāda uses independent arguments in Book II, does that **debar** him from also using reasoning in Book I? The premise does not support the conclusion.
- 2 If nothing in Book II is unintelligible without the help of Book I, how does that **necessarily** mean Book II is an absolutely independent work? Even in the works of many modern scholars there are chapters that **may be read by themselves** without thereby being separate treatises.
- 3 The third argument is **purely negative** ("there is nothing against...") and is, Sharma says, no argument at all.
- 4 Repetition is **not always useless**: an author may consider repetition necessary to **emphasise important points**. Sharma diagnoses Bhaṭṭācārya's underlying error here: he expects from Gauḍapāda — a saint — the "strictest unity and utmost homogeneity of presentation" that one might expect from a professional academic writer on philosophy. Sharma insists there **is**, in fact, a considerable unity running through the different Books of the Āgama-Śāstra.

1.3.3 The Real Merit of Bhaṭṭācārya's Work, and Sharma's Counter-Thesis

Sharma is careful to separate what he rejects from what he accepts in Bhaṭṭācārya's scholarship. The **chief merit** of Bhaṭṭācārya's work, Sharma says, is that it points out the similarities between Gauḍapāda and Mahāyāna Buddhism — and on these similarities themselves (as distinct from the chronology thesis) Sharma broadly agrees, accepting that Gauḍapāda was much influenced by Mahāyāna Buddhism, especially by Nāgārjuna and

Vasubandhu.

Sharma paraphrases Bhaṭṭācārya's own concession approvingly: that although Gauḍapāda does advocate Vijñānavāda, this idealism was originally adopted by him from an **Upaniṣadic source** — the Upaniṣadic seed of idealism was influenced by its elaborate systematic development within Buddhism and by the vast Buddhist literature of teachers who preceded Gauḍapāda, and thus developed into what we find in the Āgama-Śāstra; but it must be accepted that idealism did **not first originate** with the Buddhists, even though it was much further developed within their system later on.

Sharma's complaint is that Bhaṭṭācārya **does not develop** this important admission — he "sometimes seems to forget it." This marks Sharma's point of central disagreement, which he states as a difference of **emphasis and aim**:

Bhaṭṭācārya's aim, in cataloguing the parallels between Gauḍapāda and Mahāyāna, is more or less to prove that **Gauḍapāda is a Crypto-Buddhist**.

Sharma's aim, by contrast, is to prove that **Mahāyāna and Advaita are not two opposed systems of thought** but only different stages in the development of the **same** thought — a thought which originates in the Upaniṣads. Both Gauḍapāda's philosophy and Mahāyāna (insofar as Gauḍapāda agrees with it) are rooted in the Upaniṣads. Therefore, Sharma concludes, instead of dubbing Gauḍapāda a Crypto-Buddhist, **it would be far truer to dub the Mahāyānists crypto-Vedāntins**.

Sharma flags that he will pursue this reversal of the usual framing further (this becomes the explicit thesis of Section V and recurs in the following chapter on Śaṅkara).

II. AJĀTIVĀDA — THE DOCTRINE OF NO-ORINATION

This is **the fundamental doctrine of Gauḍapāda**, and Sharma devotes the longest section of the chapter to unpacking it clause by clause.

2.1 Definition

- **Negatively:** the world, being only an appearance, is in fact never created.
- **Positively:** the Absolute, being self-existent, is never created — it is *aja*, the Unborn.

Gauḍapāda agrees with Śūnyavāda that origination, from the absolute standpoint, is an impossibility.

2.2 The Rejected Theories of Creation

Gauḍapāda surveys the standing theories of how creation occurs and rejects all of them:

- Creation is the **expansion** (*vibhūti*) of God.
- Creation is like a **dream** (*svapna*) or an **illusion** (*māyā*).
- Creation is the **will** (*icchā*) of God.
- Creation proceeds from **Time** (*kāla*).
- Creation is for God's **enjoyment** (*bhoga*).
- Creation is God's **sport** (*krīḍā*).

Gauḍapāda's refutation of the "sport" and "enjoyment" theories in particular rests on a pointed rhetorical question: **what desire can God have, who has already realised all desires?** A being of complete self-fulfilment has no motive left that could explain creation as a purposive act.

2.3 What Creation Really Is — Emanation as Mere Appearance

Essentially, therefore, creation is simply the **very nature** of God: it flows from Him, it simply **emanates** from Him, exactly as heat emanates from fire, without any deliberation or desire being involved (Kārikā I, 7-9). **But this is only how it appears** — in fact **there is no creation at all**. Gauḍapāda's reasoning: if this world of plurality really existed, it would have surely come to an end (everything compounded is subject to dissolution); since duality never in fact ends, **duality is only an appearance**, and **non-duality is the real truth** (Kārikā I, 17).

To those well-versed in Vedānta, the world appears only as a **dream**, an **illusion**, a **castle in the sky**, or a **city of the Gandharvas** (*gandharva-nagara*) — the classical Indian image for a beautiful mirage-city that has no substantial existence (Kārikā II, 31).

2.4 The Ultimate Standpoint: A Series of Negations

From the ultimate standpoint there is neither death nor birth, neither disappearance nor appearance, neither destruction nor production, neither bondage nor liberation. There is **none** who works for freedom, **none** who desires salvation, and **none** who has been liberated — there is neither the aspirant nor the emancipated. **This is the highest truth.** There is neither unity nor plurality: the world cannot be regarded as manifold by its own nature. It is neither one nor many — "thus the wise know it."

2.5 Neither One Nor Many: The Rope-Snake Analogy

The imagination of the Ātman as different things, and the imagination of the different things themselves — which in fact do not exist — both depend upon the Non-dual Absolute (the Pure Ātman), exactly as the imagination of a snake, in the well-known case of the rope mistaken for a snake in twilight, depends entirely upon the rope. **The Absolute alone, therefore, is blissful.** (This rope-snake analogy is Gauḍapāda's central illustrative device and recurs, developed further, in Section III below.)

2.6 Reality as No-Origination, and the Status of Upaniṣadic Creation-Texts

Reality **is** No-origination. It always remains the same; it is the complete absence of misery. Understanding this at once explains how things which in fact are never born can nevertheless appear as if they are born. The Absolute is Non-dual: there is no difference at all in it.

This raises an interpretive problem: the Upaniṣads themselves frequently **do** speak of creation as distinct from its cause, using illustrations such as earth (clay and the objects made of it), or iron and the sparks that fly from it. Gauḍapāda's resolution is that such passages function only as a pedagogical **means** (*upāya*): the Upaniṣads teach creation-language **only in order to lead the pupil toward** the supreme end, which is the understanding of No-origination. The doctrine of creation is thus a concession to the learner's level, not a statement of ultimate truth.

2.7 The Identity Chain: Jagat = Jīva = Ātman = Brahman

Jagat (the world) is not different from Jīva (the individual soul); Jīva is not different from Ātman; Ātman is not different from Brahman. The non-dual Absolute appears diverse only **on account of illusion**. The Unborn can never tolerate any real distinction within itself: if it really became diverse, then the Immortal would have to become mortal.

2.8 Why the Immortal Cannot Become Mortal

This becomes Gauḍapāda's core dialectical weapon against every dualist cosmogony. The dualists want to prove **the birth of the Unborn**. But the Unborn is, by definition, Immortal — and **how can the Immortal become mortal?** The Immortal can never become mortal, and the mortal can never become Immortal, because **ultimate nature can never change**. Any theory of creation that requires the unchanging Absolute literally to become the changing many is, on this ground alone, self-contradictory.

2.9 Śruti Testimony for Ajātivāda

Gauḍapāda marshals four Upaniṣadic passages in support:

- 1 "There is no plurality here" (*neha nānāsti kiñcana*) — Bṛhadāraṇyaka IV.4.19 and Kaṭha II.1.11.
- 2 "The Lord, through His power, appears to be many" — Bṛhadāraṇyaka II.5.19.
- 3 "The Unborn appears to be born as many" (*ajāyamāno bahudhā vijāyate*) — from which it follows that the Unborn appears to be born **only through illusion**; in fact He is never born.
- 4 By declaring that "those who are attached to creation, production, or origination (*sambhūti*) go to utter darkness" (Īśā 12), the Śruti **denies creation**; and by declaring that "the Unborn does not take birth again — who, then, can indeed produce Him?" (Bṛhadāraṇyaka III.9.28), the Śruti **denies the cause of creation**.

2.10 Independent Rational Proof of No-Origination

Not only Śruti but **independent reasoning** can also prove that ultimately nothing originates:

- Whoever maintains the birth of **the existent** accepts the absurd position that **that which already exists is being born again**.
- **The non-existent**, on the other hand, can never be born at all — illustrated by the classic Indian image: the son of a barren woman can be born **neither through illusion nor in reality**, because there is simply no such entity to be born.

Therefore the doctrine of No-origination is the ultimate truth — arrived at independently of scriptural authority, by reason alone.

2.11 The Self-Cancelling Quarrel of the Dualists

Gauḍapāda observes that dualists quarrel endlessly among themselves: some say it is **the existent** which is born, others say it is **the non-existent** which is born; some say nothing originates from **Being**, others say nothing originates from **Not-being**. Gauḍapāda's striking move is to decline to enter this quarrel at all: "**we do not quarrel with these dualists,**" he says, **because these disputants, taken together, proclaim — like the non-dualists — the doctrine of No-origination**. Each side, in refuting the other's account of how the Unborn is born, ends up showing that **no** coherent account of the birth of the Unborn is available. How, after all, can the Unborn be born at all? How can the Immortal become mortal? Ultimate nature cannot change: it is self-proved, self-existent, innate, and uncaused. All things, by their very nature, are free from decay and death; those who believe in decay and death fall into error precisely on account of this wrong notion.

2.12 Agreement with Śūnyavāda's Advayavāda

There are some — the Śūnyavādins — who uphold non-dualism (*advayavāda*) and reject **both** extreme views, of being and not-being, of production and destruction, thereby

emphatically proclaiming the doctrine of No-origination. Gauḍapāda states his approval explicitly: **"We approve of the doctrine of No-origination as proclaimed by the Śūnyavādins."**

2.13 Refutation of the Sāṅkhya Satkāryavāda

Sāṅkhya maintains *satkāryavāda*: the effect pre-exists in the cause, and causation consists simply in the **manifestation** of the permanent cause (*avyakta*, the unmanifest) as the changing effects (*vyakta jagat*, the manifest world). Gauḍapāda raises a cluster of objections:

- 1 If the cause is **produced** (i.e., manifested as effect), how can it remain **unborn**?
- 2 If the cause becomes the changing "many," how can it remain **changeless and permanent**?
- 3 If the effect is **identical** with the cause, then either the effect too should be immortal, or the cause too should be mortal — how can the permanent cause be identical with the changing effect and still remain permanent? Śāṅkara's Commentary supplies a vivid illustration of this objection: **one cannot cook half a hen for dinner and simultaneously reserve the other half of the very same hen for laying eggs** — a single entity cannot be exploited in two mutually incompatible modes at once.
- 4 If, alternatively, the effect does **not** pre-exist in the cause, then it is like a **hare's horn** — a pure non-entity — and cannot be produced at all.
- 5 Cause and effect cannot be **simultaneous** either, for then the two horns of a bull — which arise together — would have to be regarded as causally related to one another, which they plainly are not.
- 6 Finally, those who maintain that the cause precedes the effect **and** that the effect precedes the cause (i.e., that the relation runs both ways) maintain the absurd position that **a son also begets his own father**.

Therefore, Gauḍapāda concludes, nothing whatsoever can be produced.

2.14 Three Formal Reasons Nothing Can Originate

Beyond the specific critique of Sāṅkhya, Gauḍapāda gives three general reasons why origination as such is impossible:

- 1 **Lack of energy in the cause.** A cause must possess some definite energy in order to produce its effect — otherwise **everything** could be produced from **everything**, or **nothing** could be produced from **anything**. But this requisite energy cannot belong either to that which is existent, or to that which is non-existent, or to that which is both existent-and-non-existent, or to that which is neither — the four logically exhaustive alternatives (the *catuṣkoṭi*) are all closed off.

- 2 **Absence of knowledge of the beginning and the end.** The effect, being neither existent at the beginning nor existent at the end, must equally be non-existent in the middle.
- 3 **Incompatibility of the order of succession.** Antecedence and consequence are themselves unproved: we cannot say which of the two, cause or effect, is prior, and is therefore entitled to be called "the cause."

2.15 Concluding Formulations

Thus, says Gauḍapāda, **the Buddhas, the Enlightened, have clarified the doctrine of No-origination**: causality is therefore an impossibility. It cannot be proved that Saṃsāra is beginningless yet has an end, nor can it be proved that Mokṣa has a beginning yet has no end — both of the usual asymmetrical accounts collapse under scrutiny.

In truth, it is the Unborn itself which merely **appears** as if it were born; therefore No-origination is the very nature of the Unborn. That which exists neither at the beginning nor at the end cannot exist in the middle either; that which is unreal in the past and unreal in the future must be unreal in the present too. Origination is impossible because neither the existent nor the non-existent can be produced, either by the existent or by the non-existent — every combinatorial possibility of causation is exhausted and rejected.

III. REALITY AS PURE CONSCIOUSNESS — CONVERGENCE WITH VIJÑĀNAVĀDA

3.1 The Basic Agreement

Gauḍapāda agrees with the Vijñānavādins in maintaining that the world is ultimately unreal, because it cannot exist independently and outside of Consciousness, which alone is Reality. Sharma notes that even **Śaṅkara himself** acknowledges that Gauḍapāda accepts the Vijñānavādin arguments for the unreality of external objects.

3.2 Why the Un-philosophical Believe in the World's Reality

Ordinary people cling to the view that the world exists because (a) things **are perceived**, and (b) there is **practical utility** (*artha-kriyā*-type efficacy) in dealing with them. They are, Gauḍapāda says, always afraid of the doctrine of No-origination. It is for the sake of **such** ordinary people that the Buddhas, speaking from the **phenomenal** standpoint, have proclaimed origination at all. But from the **ultimate** standpoint, perception and practical utility are invalid arguments for the reality of the world — because both perception and practical utility can equally be found in a **magical elephant** conjured by an illusionist, and in the objects of a **dream**. If perception-plus-utility were sufficient to establish reality, dream-objects and magical apparitions would have to be granted reality too; since they are not, perception and utility cannot be the test of reality.

3.3 The Sārvāstivāda-Vijñānavāda Debate on External Objects

Sharma reports a debate between two Buddhist schools that Gauḍapāda draws on:

The Sārvāstivāda position (*para-tantra*). The Sārvāstivādins refute the Vijñānavādins and advocate the real existence of external objects. Their argument: cognition must have an **objective cause**, otherwise the very distinction between subject and object would be impossible. External objects must exist because cognition and suffering are **dependent** (*para-tantra*, "dependent on another") upon them.

The Vijñānavādin reply. The upholders of external objects want to show that cognition must have a cause — but the "objective cause" they adduce is, on inspection, no cause at all. The object exists **as an object for the knowing subject**; but it does not exist **outside of consciousness**, because the very distinction between subject and object is itself internal to consciousness. Consciousness is the sole reality, and it is never actually related to any external object — not in the past, not in the present, not in the future.

Gauḍapāda's verdict: he is in complete agreement with the Vijñānavādins on this point.

3.4 Three Reasons the External World Is Unreal

The external world is unreal, on this analysis, for three distinct reasons:

- 1 It does **not exist always**, as genuine Reality must.

- 2 The **relations** that constitute it are themselves all unreal, because **space, time, and causality** are, on ultimate analysis, impossible.
- 3 It **consists of objects**, and whatever can be presented as an object is, for that very reason, unreal (since the object-status itself is internal to and dependent on consciousness — cf. 3.3 above).

Reality is the **Pure Self**, which is Pure Consciousness, standing at the background of everything.

3.5 Waking and Dream: On a Par, Though Unreal

The waking state and the dreaming state are, for Gauḍapāda, **on a par**: both are real **within their own order**. The water drunk in a dream can quench thirst **in the dream** just as effectively as real water quenches real thirst in waking life. Both states are alike — though **not equally** — unreal, when judged from the ultimate standpoint. (Note the careful qualification "though not equally": Gauḍapāda does not simply collapse waking and dreaming into total identity; this qualification becomes the seed of Śaṅkara's later, sharper distinction — see 3.8 below.)

3.6 The Self Imagining Itself: Rope-Snake Extended

The self-luminous Self, through its own power of illusion (*māyā*), imagines itself by itself, and it is this very Self which then cognises the manifold objects it has imagined. This, Sharma notes, is the "established conclusion of Vedānta." Just as in darkness a rope is imagined to be a snake, so the Self is imagined to be individual subjects, mental states, and external objects; and just as the imagined snake vanishes the instant the rope is recognised, so the entire subject-object duality vanishes at once when the non-dual Ātman is realised. The luminous Self, through its own power of illusion, becomes as it were "infatuated" with itself — it is **Consciousness itself** which throbs as the subject and as the object, both in dream and in waking.

This whole universe — this entire duality of subject and object — is therefore only the **imagination of the Self**. Neither the individual soul nor the external object is ultimately real. Those who believe they see the creation of the individual self, or of the external object, are, Gauḍapāda says, like those who claim to see the **footprints of birds in the sky** — a classical Indian figure for something that categorically does not exist. External objects are not even the creation of the individual self; both subject and object alike are **only manifestations of Consciousness**. Whatever has merely **empirical** existence cannot, for that reason, be called ultimately real.

3.7 Consciousness as Asaṅga

Consciousness, though immanent in both the subject and the object, **transcends them both**: it transcends the entire trinity of knower, known, and knowledge. Consciousness is really **Asaṅga** (unattached) — it has no attachment, connection, or relation with anything else at all. It is called "Unborn" (*aja*) only from the empirical standpoint; from the ultimate standpoint it cannot even be called "Unborn," for it is **strictly indescribable by intellect**.

Realising the truth of No-origination, one bids farewell to all sorrow and desire, and reaches the fearless goal.

3.8 Where Śaṅkara Goes Further Than Gauḍapāda

Sharma inserts an important comparative note, previewing the following chapter. We have seen that Gauḍapāda agrees with Vijñānavāda that Reality is Pure Consciousness, which manifests itself as — and ultimately transcends — the subject-object duality. Śaṅkara, we shall see, bitterly criticises Vijñānavāda; but much of that criticism, Sharma observes, **loses its force against Vijñānavāda properly understood**, since Vijñānavāda does not deny the **objectivity** of the external world — only its existence **outside of** consciousness. Śaṅkara himself, in a sense, admits as much.

Nonetheless, Śaṅkara's own view represents a **definite advance** on both Vijñānavāda and Gauḍapāda, in one specific respect: Śaṅkara **emphasises that the dream-state and the waking-state are not on a par** (recall Gauḍapāda's more qualified position at 3.5). Rather than proving the unreality of the external world by saying that it falls outside of consciousness, Śaṅkara proves it by saying that the world is essentially **indescribable** as either existent or non-existent (*sadasad-anirvacanīya*).

Sharma is emphatic, however, that this "indescribability" doctrine is **not an altogether new creation of Śaṅkara**. It was developed already within Śūnyavāda and was accepted by Gauḍapāda himself: Gauḍapāda too says that the world is unreal because it is essentially indescribable or unthinkable, either as existent or as non-existent.

3.9 The Alātaśānti (Firebrand) Analogy

Gauḍapāda illustrates the indescribability doctrine with the famous firebrand analogy: just as a **moving firebrand** (*alāta*) appears as a straight or a curved line of light (depending how it is whirled), so Consciousness, when it "moves," appears as the subject-object duality. And just as an **unmoving** firebrand produces no such illusion, so unwavering, unflinching knowledge produces no subject-object illusion at all.

The appearances seen in a moving firebrand are not produced by anything else; and when the firebrand stops moving, those appearances do not **rest** in anything else, nor do they **enter into** the firebrand, nor do they **go out of** it — they simply cease to be seen. Similarly, the manifold phenomena of the world are not produced by anything other than Consciousness; they do not rest in anything else; they do not enter into Consciousness; they do not go out of it. **They are mere appearances**, and they are mere appearances precisely because **they are essentially indescribable or unthinkable** — they can be called **neither real nor unreal**, neither existent nor non-existent.

Sharma notes that this position is strengthened by Gauḍapāda's overall agreement with Śūnyavāda, by his doctrine of No-origination, and by his maintaining throughout that the world is neither existent, nor non-existent, nor both. **This doctrine of Avidyā was further developed by Śaṅkara** — the thread that the next chapter picks up.

IV. ASPARŚAYOGA — GAUḌAPĀDA'S ORIGINAL CONTRIBUTION

4.1 Definition and Sources

We now turn to Gauḍapāda's **own** contribution — not merely synthesised from Upaniṣad and Buddhist material but original to him: the doctrine of **Vaiśāradya**, or **Asparśayoga**, or **Amanībhāva**. Even this doctrine, Sharma notes, was **hinted at by the Buddhists** — Āryadeva, for instance, writes "*nahyasparśavato nāma yogaḥ sparśavatā saha*" (*Catuḥśataka*, verse 333), and the Vijñānavādins had prescribed various yogic disciplines for *Amanībhāva*, i.e. the transformation of the relational intellect into Pure Consciousness. But it is **essentially based on the Upaniṣads**, and its systematic development is Gauḍapāda's own.

Taking his stand on the Bṛhadāraṇyaka, the Chāndogya and the Māṇḍūkya, Gauḍapāda identifies the Unborn, Non-dual Absolute with the **Ātman-Brahman-Amātra-Turiya-Advaita** complex, which can be **directly realised** by Pure Knowledge, i.e. by Asparśayoga, Vaiśāradya, or Amanībhāva.

This Absolute manifests itself in three empirical forms — in *Jāgrat* (waking), *Svapna* (dream), and *Suṣupti* (deep sleep) — as **Viśva**, **Taijasa**, and **Prājña** respectively. In reality it transcends all three forms: it is **Turiya**, the Fourth. It is the **Measureless** or the **Amātra**. *Praṇava* or *Aumkāra* (the syllable Om) is its symbol — and in fact there is **no distinction** between the symbol and the symbolised: *Praṇava* itself is the Brahman, the Fearless Goal. It is cause as well as effect; phenomenal as well as noumenal; *saguṇa* as well as *nirguṇa*; *apara* as well as *para*. It is the shining Self, the self-luminous Consciousness.

4.2 The Fourfold Scheme of Consciousness

The four states are correlated with three empirical conditions plus the transcendent Fourth as follows:

State	Corresponds to	Consciousness of	Enjoys	Cause / Effect status
Viśva ("All")	Jāgrat (waking)	the outside	the gross	both cause and effect
Taijasa ("Luminous")	Svapna (dream)	the inside	the subtle	both cause and effect
Prājña ("Intelligent")	Suṣupti (deep sleep)	concentrated consciousness	bliss	cause only
Turiya ("the Fourth")	transcends all three	all-seeing, self-luminous	—	neither cause nor effect

Turīya is called **Īśāna**, **Prabhu**, or **Deva**. It is all-pervading, capable of removing all suffering, lord of all, changeless, non-dual, luminous, one without a second.

4.3 Prājña as Mere Abstraction; Turīya as All-Seeing

Prājña knows no objects at all, and therefore **cannot even be called a subject** — it is a mere abstraction. It knows nothing: neither itself nor others, neither truth nor falsehood. Turīya, by contrast, being pure and self-luminous Consciousness, is **all-seeing**. Although duality is equally absent from both Prājña and Turīya, the two are not the same: **Prājña is connected with deep sleep**, where the seed of ignorance is still present, whereas **Turīya knows no sleep whatsoever**.

Viśva and Taijasa are connected with **dream or false knowledge** (*anyathā-grahaṇa* or *vikṣepa*, "distraction") and with **sleep or the absence of knowledge** (*agrahaṇa*, *āvaraṇa*, or *laya*, "dissolution"); Prājña is connected with sleep. In Turīya there is neither sleep nor dream.

4.4 Waking Life as Also a Dream

In dream, we know things **otherwise** than they are (falsely); in sleep, we do not know the truth at all. Gauḍapāda's striking further claim: **the so-called waking life is also a dream** — because it too consists in relational, subject-object knowledge of the *vikṣepa* type, differing from dream only in degree, not in kind. When the negative absence of knowledge which is sleep, and the positive wrong knowledge which constitutes both dream and waking, are together transcended, **the Fourth, the Goal, is reached**. The fearless light of the self-luminous Self then shines all around.

4.5 The Awakening of the Jīva

When the individual self (*jīva*), slumbering in beginningless Ignorance, is awakened, then the Unborn, the Dreamless, the Sleepless, the Non-dual Absolute (*ātman*) is realised. It **moves nowhere**; there is no going to it and no coming from it. It is the Lord immanent in the universe, abiding in the hearts of all. He alone is a sage (*muni*) who has embraced this infinite and measureless *Aumkāra*, which is the cessation of all duality and which is all bliss. All the categories of the intellect are merged in it; all plurality of phenomena ceases here. It is realised by the sages who have known the essence of the Vedas, and who are free from fear, anger, and attachment.

4.6 The Space-in-Jars Analogy (Ghaṭākāśa)

Gauḍapāda develops an extended analogy to explain the relation between individual souls and the one Ātman, using space (*ākāśa*) enclosed in jars:

- Ātman is like **space**; individual souls are like the **space inside particular jars**. When the jars are destroyed, their enclosed spaces simply merge back into total Space. Likewise, the *jīvas* merge into the Ātman when Ignorance is destroyed by Right Knowledge.

- Just as, if the space in one particular jar is contaminated with dust or smoke, the spaces in **all other jars do not thereby become contaminated**, so too, if one particular jīva is affected by happiness or misery, all other jīvas are **not** thereby affected.
- Spaces in different jars differ in **form, function, and name**, but there is **no actual difference in space itself**; likewise jīvas differ in form, function, and name, but there is no actual difference in the Ātman.
- Just as the space enclosed in a jar is **neither a transformation, nor a modification, nor a part** of space as such, so a jīva is neither a transformation, nor a modification, nor a part of the Ātman.
- Ultimately, therefore, **there are no grades of reality and no degrees of truth**. The same immanent Absolute is reflected in all pairs of objects related by "sweet reciprocity" (*madhu-vidyā*), in the microcosm as much as in the macrocosm — exactly as the same space is immanent both in the world outside and inside the human stomach.

4.7 Madhu-vidyā: Microcosm and Macrocosm

The reference to *madhu-vidyā* (the "honey-doctrine" of the Bṛhadāraṇyaka and Chāndogya) points to the broader Upaniṣadic teaching that each element of the macrocosm (the universe) and the corresponding element of the microcosm (the individual) are bound together in a relation of mutual "honey-like" sweetness or interdependence — a correspondence which, for Gauḍapāda, ultimately expresses the single underlying Ātman common to both scales.

4.8 Upāya-kausālya: The Three Grades of Aspirants

Just as the Mahāyānist say that the Buddha, on account of his excellent skill (*upāya-kausālya*), preached the truth differently to suit the different needs of the *śrāvakas*, the *pratyeka-buddhas*, and the *bodhisattvas*, so Gauḍapāda says that the "Merciful Veda" prescribes **three different spiritual stages** (*āśramas*) suited to **three kinds of people** — of lower, middle, and higher intellect. **Karma** and **upāsana** (ritual action and devotional meditation) are taught to the lower and the middle aspirants, while **jñāna** (direct knowledge) is taught only to the higher.

4.9 Why the Advaitin Quarrels With None

It is only the **dualists** who quarrel with one another, each side seeking to strengthen its own position. **The Advaitin quarrels with none**. For the dualists, duality holds both from the empirical and from the absolute standpoint. For the Advaitin, non-duality is the ultimate truth — and, strikingly, for the Advaitin there is **non-duality (advaita) even between unity and diversity** themselves: the very opposition of *advaita* and *dvaita* is, at the deepest level, not itself an ultimate duality.

4.10 Neti Neti and the Method of Negation

The famous *neti neti* ("not this, not this") of the Śruti is not mere negativism or nihilism: by negating all plurality and difference, the Śruti in fact **manifests the positive Unborn, the Absolute**. The underlying reason for this method is that the Absolute **cannot be grasped by the intellect** at all, so that the best available method of describing the Indescribable is by way of **negative terms**. But all these negations, however many, ultimately point toward one and the same ineffable Reality. Duality itself is the **creation of the intellect**; when the intellect is transcended (*amanībhāva*, "the state of no-mind"), duality and plurality simply disappear.

4.11 Asparśayoga Defined as Fearless Meditation

What remains, on transcending the intellect, is pure Consciousness, devoid of all thought-determinations and imagination. It is Unborn, and not different from the Knowable (*jñeya*). The Knowable is the Brahman. It is calm and eternal Light. It is the fearless and unshakable Meditation (*samādhi*) — it is **Asparśayoga**, the "Uncontaminated Meditation," difficult to attain even by great yogins. Yogins themselves are often afraid of it, imagining fear where there is in reality no fear at all. Verily, the absence of fear, the end of suffering, perpetual wakefulness, and eternal peace all depend upon the **control of mind**.

4.12 Laya and Vikṣepa: The Two Dangers

When both **laya** (dissolution, lapsing into sleep-like torpor) and **vikṣepa** (distraction, scattering outward into objects) are transcended — when the mind neither falls into sleep nor is again distracted — it becomes unshakable and free from illusion, and **it becomes Brahman**. The aspirant should remain free from attachment, and equally free from both misery and happiness.

4.13 Nirvāṇa as Bliss Beyond Misery and Happiness

When Brahman is thus realised, there arises a **unique Bliss** which transcends both misery and happiness alike, and which is called **Nirvāṇa**. It is indescribable, the highest, and unshakable. It is Unborn, non-dual, and always the same. Gauḍapāda states pointedly: **it can be realised by the Buddhas only**.

4.14 The Four Koṭis as False Coverings

The ignorant perceive only a **four-fold "covering"** (*āvaraṇa*) over the Absolute, corresponding to the four logical alternatives (*koṭi*) of the intellect: "is," "is not," "both is and is not," and "neither is nor is not." The Absolute merely **appears** to be obscured by these four categories; in fact it is **never actually touched** by any of them. He who has transcended all four categories and embraced the Pure Self realises the Absolute and becomes **omniscient**.

4.15 Omniscience and Transcendental Knowledge

Omniscience results precisely when the trinity of **knowledge, knower, and known** is transcended. This is **Transcendental Knowledge** (*lokottaram jñānam*). One who has

realised this Omniscience, this non-dual Brahman, this Goal befitting a true Brāhmaṇa — what else could such a person possibly desire? All souls, by their very nature, are **always already** in the state of enlightenment. All elements of existence, subjective as well as objective, are by their very nature calm from the very beginning, Unborn, and merged in the Absolute — because they are nothing other than the Brahman itself, which is Unborn, Same, and Transparent. Those who move in the realm of difference can never acquire transcendental purity (*vaiśāradya*); their case, Gauḍapāda says, is "indeed pitiable."

4.16 The Closing Salutation

Gauḍapāda closes this movement of the Kārikā with a salutation: **"We salute that Highest Reality, which is Unborn, Same, Pure, and Free from all traces of duality and plurality, according to the best of our ability."**

He who has become the Buddha, the Enlightened, has a knowledge (*jñānam*) that is **not related to anything** (*dharmeṣu na kramate*) — neither to the subject nor to the object — because it is supra-relational; nor is anything whatsoever (*sarve dharmāḥ*), whether subject or object, related to his knowledge, because there is nothing at all outside his knowledge. He has transcended the duality of subject and object, and the trinity of knowledge, knower and known. **He has become one with Pure Consciousness.**

V. CONCLUSION — GAUḌAPĀDA'S RELATION TO BUDDHISM

5.1 The Salutation to "the Greatest of Men"

We have seen throughout how Gauḍapāda agrees with both Śūnyavāda and Vijñānavāda, and he has great respect for the Buddha. He writes: **"Him, one of the Greatest of Men, who has known the truth that the individual souls (*dharmāḥ*) are identical with the pure Self (*jñeya*), I salute."** Śaṅkara explains that this "Greatest of Men" is **Puruṣottama**, i.e. **Nārāyaṇa**, the sage of Badarikāśrama and the first teacher of the Advaita School. But Sharma notes that this line, as it stands, **may equally refer to the Buddha** — the reference is genuinely ambiguous, and this ambiguity is itself significant for Sharma's overall thesis.

5.2 Shared Vocabulary Is Not Mahāyāna's Monopoly

Gauḍapāda uses many words and expressions that were also frequently used in Mahāyāna works. Sharma insists this proves less than it might seem to: these words were **not the exclusive property of the Mahāyāna**. They were, rather, the **current philosophical coinage of the day**, part of the shared **heritage of the [Sanskrit philosophical] language**, and Gauḍapāda had every right to make use of them without thereby becoming a Buddhist in doctrine.

5.3 Gauḍapāda's Impartiality

Sharma is unstinting in his praise of Gauḍapāda's intellectual character: his **impartial spirit** is much to be admired. His breadth of vision, his large-heartedness, his broad intellectual outlook, and his impartial spirit all add to his glory and greatness. He has genuine respect for the Buddha, and frankly admits that in certain respects he agrees with both Śūnyavādins and Vijñānavādins.

5.4 Sharma's Thesis: Not a Crypto-Buddhist But a Thorough Vedāntin

But none of this, Sharma insists, should be taken to mean that Gauḍapāda is a **crypto-Buddhist**. On the contrary: **he is a thorough-going Vedāntin, in and out**. His mission is precisely to prove that Mahāyāna Buddhism and Advaita Vedānta are **not two opposed systems of thought**, but only a continuation of the **same fundamental thought of the Upaniṣads**. He has based his entire philosophy on the Upaniṣads (recall 1.1 and 1.3.4 above, where this thesis was first announced).

5.5 Interpreting "This Truth Was Not Uttered by Buddha"

Gauḍapāda closes the Kārikā with the striking declaration that **"this truth was not uttered by Buddha."** Sharma reads this not as a denial that Buddha taught truth, but as a precise philosophical claim with three components:

- 1 Gauḍapāda's own philosophy, and the philosophy of Buddha and of the Mahāyāna — **insofar as** Gauḍapāda agrees with it — are **both directly rooted in the Upaniṣads**.
- 2 The Buddha preached this **Upaniṣadic Truth** not by words, but by **silence** (an allusion to the tradition of the Buddha's silence on metaphysical questions).
- 3 Gauḍapāda's own preaching **is** the essence of the Vedānta — it is **not** an original contribution either of Buddha or of the Buddhists.

This closing move completes the reversal Sharma proposed at the very start of the chapter (1.3.4): rather than treating the doctrinal overlap between Gauḍapāda and Mahāyāna as evidence that Advaita is covertly Buddhist, Sharma reads the same evidence as showing that **Mahāyāna Buddhism, in its idealist and śūnyavādin dimensions, is itself continuous with — and arguably derivative of — the older Upaniṣadic thought that both traditions share.**

SUMMARY OF THE ARGUMENTATIVE ARCHITECTURE OF THE CHAPTER

For quick revision, the chapter's argument moves through four interlocking claims, each building on the last:

- 1 **Textual claim (Section I):** the Kārikā is a genuine, unified commentary on/development of the Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad, and Gauḍapāda stands to the Upaniṣads as Nāgārjuna stands to the Mahāyāna-Sūtras.
- 2 **Metaphysical claim (Section II, Ajātivāda):** nothing is ever really created — established by (a) rejection of all standard creation-theories, (b) Śruti citation, (c) independent reasoning (existent/non-existent dilemma), (d) refutation of Sāṅkhya satkāryavāda, and (e) the three formal proofs against causation as such.
- 3 **Epistemological claim (Section III):** Reality is Pure Consciousness alone; the external world's unreality is established via convergence with, and eventual refinement beyond, Vijñānavāda — culminating in the indescribability (*anirvacanīya*) doctrine and the Alātaśānti analogy.
- 4 **Soteriological claim (Section IV, Asparśayoga):** the fourfold scheme of consciousness (Viśva-Taijasa-Prājña-Turīya) maps the path from ignorance to the direct, "untouched" realisation of the Absolute, achieved by transcending both laya and vikṣepa.

*The chapter's final interpretive payoff (Section V) is Sharma's larger historiographical thesis: the extensive overlap in vocabulary and argument between Gauḍapāda and the Mahāyāna schools should be read as evidence of a **common Upaniṣadic root**, not as evidence that Advaita Vedānta is secretly Buddhist.*